



Mind Over Matter? Substance and Property Dualism

An original lesson plan inspired by **Howard Robinson & Ralph Weir's** the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* entry on *Dualism*. Not affiliated with or endorsed by *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* or *Howard Robinson & Ralph Weir*. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/dualism/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

60 minutes

TOPICS

Philosophy of Mind

“Is your mind made of the very same stuff as your body, or is mental life — thoughts, feelings, the experience of red — something fundamentally different from anything physical?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Distinguish substance dualism (mind and body are two different kinds of things) from property dualism (one kind of thing, matter, that has two irreducibly different kinds of properties).
- Reconstruct Descartes' conceivability argument and his divisibility argument for the distinctness of mind and body.
- Evaluate the interaction problem as an objection to dualism and assess whether contemporary property dualism escapes it.

Materials Needed

- Handout with paraphrased passages capturing Descartes' key moves in Meditation VI (the conceivability and divisibility arguments)
- Comparison diagram: substance dualism vs. property dualism vs. physicalism, with blank boxes for students to fill in during lecture
- Whiteboard for diagramming the pineal-gland interaction problem
- Index cards for the divisibility thought experiment (half marked BODY, half marked MIND)

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Can You Lose Half a Thought?

8 min

Ask students to physically point to 'half of their left hand' (easy) and then to point to 'half of the thought I am having right now' (impossible, and they will notice it). Use this to introduce Descartes' observation that bodies are divisible into parts but a single thought or belief doesn't seem to have a left half and a right half the way a physical object does.

Direct Instruction: Descartes' Two Arguments

15 min

Present the conceivability argument (I can clearly and distinctly conceive of my mind existing without my body, therefore they are not identical) and the divisibility argument (body is essentially divisible and extended in space; mind is essentially unified and non-spatial; things with different essential properties cannot be identical). Introduce the substance/property dualism distinction: substance dualists say there are two fundamentally different kinds of stuff, while property dualists say there is only physical stuff, but some of its properties, like the felt quality of pain, cannot be reduced to or explained by physical properties.

Small-Group Case Work: The Interaction Problem

20 min

In groups, students diagram how a non-physical mind is supposed to cause a physical body to move, such as deciding to raise an arm, using Descartes' own proposed pineal-gland mechanism as a starting point. Groups must identify precisely where the causal story breaks down: how can something with no location, mass, or extension exert physical force on something that has all three, without violating conservation of energy? Each group produces a one-sentence statement of the interaction problem in its own words.

Whole-Class Discussion: Does Property Dualism Escape the Problem?

12 min

Present property dualism as a way of avoiding substance-crossing causation, since there is only one kind of substance, the physical brain. Push on whether it still owes an explanation of how irreducibly mental properties arise from, or affect, physical ones, introducing epiphenomenalism as one controversial way out.

Closure: Where Do You Stand?

5 min

Students vote dualist, physicalist, or undecided, and one representative from each position states the single strongest reason for their vote.

Discussion Questions

- 1 If you can conceive of your mind existing without your body, does that really prove they could exist apart, or does conceivability just show the limits of your imagination rather than the nature of reality?
- 2 Is the interaction problem a decisive objection to substance dualism, or could future physics reveal a mechanism we simply haven't discovered yet?
- 3 Does property dualism actually solve the interaction problem, or does it just relocate the mystery from how two substances interact to how physical processes produce irreducibly mental properties?
- 4 Is epiphenomenalism (mental properties exist but have no causal effects on the physical world) a coherent position, or does it make consciousness pointless in a way that's hard to accept?
- 5 Descartes thought the unity of consciousness proved the mind is a simple, non-physical substance. Could a physicalist explain that same unity without going non-physical?

Assessment

Students write a short paper explaining the difference between substance dualism and property dualism, reconstructing one of Descartes' two arguments accurately, and then stating and evaluating the interaction problem as an objection, concluding with their own reasoned verdict on whether dualism survives it. Grade on accurate reconstruction of the arguments and the quality of the reasoning in the verdict, not on which position the student ultimately favors.

Extension Activity

Have students research one contemporary physicalist theory of mind, such as functionalism or the mind-brain identity theory, and write a short comparison memo explaining how that theory tries to account for conscious experience without positing a second, non-physical substance or property, and whether they find it more or less persuasive than dualism.

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